

User Support Presentations and Meetings

In this appendix, you will learn about:

- © How to design and develop effective presentations
- © How to prepare for and participate effectively in support team meetings

Two aspects of work as a support specialist are introduced in this appendix. First, support workers often need to develop presentations. Some presentations, such as user training modules and reports on the findings and recommendations of a needs assessment project, are targeted to end users. Other presentations, such as training sessions for other support workers or progress reports on special projects, are aimed at support colleagues or managers. In all of these examples, the goal of a support specialist is to prepare an effective, professional presentation of information.

Second, support workers are often participants in or conveners of meetings. These meetings may include end users, work colleagues, vendors, and managers. The purpose of a meeting may be to gather or report on information related to special project work, or a periodic team meeting to discuss and make decisions about the activities of a support work group. In every meeting in which a support worker participates, the goal is to be an effective contributor, whether in the role of meeting convener or participant.

The purpose of this appendix is to describe some ways in which a support specialist can improve their performance related to presentations and meetings.

Introduction to Presentation Software

This appendix focuses on presentation software used as a tool to design and deliver effective presentations. For many support workers, Microsoft PowerPoint is the presentation software tool of choice, if for no other reason than it is installed and available in so many training and work environments. However, several other good presentation software tools are available, including some products that can be used at no cost. Popular examples include Zoho Show, Google Docs presentations, and Kingsoft Office Presentation. Corel's WordPerfect Office Suite includes a tool, Corel Presentations, which has many features similar to those of PowerPoint, and IBM's Lotus Symphony suite includes a Presentations tool.

ON THE WEB

For information about free and open source presentation tools, which offer varying degrees of compatibility with PowerPoint, visit one or more of these sites:

- **www.zoho.com/docs/online-presentation-tool.html**—Zoho's Show is a web-based presentation tool; free registration is required.
- **www.google.com/google-d-s/presentations**—Google Docs' presentations feature is a web-based tool; free registration is required.
- **www.ksosoft.com/product/presentation-free.html**—Kingsoft Presentation Free can be downloaded and installed without charge on a PC as part of the Kingsoft Office suite.

The purpose of this appendix is to provide suggestions about how to design an effective presentation, rather than to serve as a user's manual or tutorial on presentation software. Tutorial introductions and other learning resources on these tools are available elsewhere, as described in Figure C-1.

Presentation Tool	Learning Resources
Microsoft PowerPoint	● www.gcflearnfree.org/powerpoint2013; introduction to the 2013 version ● www.gcflearnfree.org/powerpoint2010; introduction to the 2010 version ● office.microsoft.com/en-us/powerpoint-help/training-courses-for-powerpoint-2013-HA104015465.aspx; links to several training modules for the 2013 version ● office.microsoft.com/en-us/powerpoint-help/CL010370721.aspx; links to several training modules for the 2010 version ● www.guidesandtutorials.com/powerpoint-2007-window.html; introduction to the 2007 version ● www.fgcu.edu/support/office2007/ppt/index.asp; covers 2007 version ● <i>Illustrated Course Guide: Microsoft PowerPoint 2013 Advanced</i> by David W. Beskeen, (Course Technology, 2013); editions covering the 2003, 2007, and 2010 versions are also available by the same author
Zoho Show	●  wiki.itap.purdue.edu/display/INSITE/Zoho+Show09#ZohoShow09-III.HowtouseZohoShow ● <i>Zoho 4 Everyone</i> by Nancy Conner (Que, 2009); one chapter on Show in a book that covers several Zoho tools
Google Docs presentations	● www.msigeek.com/2472/how-to-create-an-online-powerpoint-presentation-with-google-docs ● <i>Google Docs 4 Everyone</i> by Steven E. Holzner (Que, 2009); two chapters on Google presentations in a book that covers several Google Docs tools
Kingsoft Presentations	● help.kingsoftstore.com/presentation; introduces the 2012 version

Figure C-1 Tutorials on selected presentation software tools

To learn the basic features of presentation software tools, start with a PowerPoint tutorial; Zoho Show, Google Docs presentations, and Kingsoft Presentations have many of the same features as PowerPoint. All three can also read and write PowerPoint (PPT) slideshow files.

Steps to Design and Develop a Presentation

Most support workers follow a sequence of basic steps when they design and develop a presentation, no matter what the purpose. These steps are summarized in Figure C-2.

● Plan the presentation

1. Define the audience, topic, and purpose
2. Learn about the presentation location and delivery media
3. Outline the major points

● Design the presentation

4. Select a slide design
5. Select a slide background and color scheme

● Create the presentation slides

6. Choose a slide layout
7. Prepare the text for each slide
8. Add other objects to selected slides, such as sound, photos, charts, tables, movies, maps, and diagrams

● Organize the slides into a slideshow

9. Decide on the sequence of slides
10. Add transitions or animation

● Generate handout materials

11. Create presenter notes
12. Create handouts

● Deliver the presentation

Figure C-2 Basic steps to design and prepare a presentation

As with other lists of steps in this textbook, the set of steps in Figure C-2 should be considered a starting point, to which a support specialist will add, subtract, and modify as the specifics of a presentation warrant. The sections that follow provide guidelines for each of these steps.

Plan the Presentation

Step 1: Define the Audience, Topic, and Purpose

The chapters on training (Chapter 11) and technical writing (Chapter 3) emphasize the importance of (1) identifying the target audience, (2) clarifying the topic, and (3) focusing on the purpose of a presentation. These strategies apply equally to planning a presentation.

Characteristics of the audience that need to be identified include whether they are novice users, sophisticated users, user support staff, or managers. The technical experience of the audience makes a difference in the amount of technical detail, jargon terms, and acronyms that can be used in a presentation.

Without a clear definition of the presentation topic, a presenter may include material that strays from the central point. The topic definition should also identify what the presentation will *not* cover, as a way to focus on the central topic. A good presenter prepares each slide with an important question in mind: *“What information do I want the audience to take away from viewing this slide?”*

Finally, a presenter should define the purpose of the presentation—whether to inform, convince, or entertain. Since most user support presentations are not primarily entertainment, the choice is usually between an informational presentation (such as a training module) and one that tries to convince the audience to take some action or reach a decision (such as a recommendation at the conclusion of a user needs assessment project). When designing a presentation, consider whether the presentation will be presented one time or at several events (for example, a product information presentation might be presented multiple times). Presentations that are offered on more than one occasion or that will be available for an extended period on the web usually require more time and effort to polish. In any case, every presentation represents both the presenter and the organization, and should be the most professional product that can be prepared in the time allocated to it.

Step 2: Learn About the Presentation Location and Delivery Media

During the presentation planning stage, a preparer should identify the location where the presentation will be delivered. Location is important for a variety of reasons. A presenter should determine, for instance, whether the presentation room will be brightly or dimly lit. In brightly lit rooms, darker slides can be used for visibility, but lighter slides should be used in a dimly lit room.

Early in the design process, identify the equipment that will be available to host the presentation. Some presentations occur in a meeting room equipped with a computer, projector, and screen. If a computer-equipped meeting room is available, does the projector include a handheld remote unit that can control the computer's mouse? Is the projector or computer enabled for sound? Or, lacking a computer projection system, will the presentation need to be printed on overhead slides for an older projection system?

Other presentations are targeted for audience access via the web or as printed handouts. If web access is the delivery medium, will sound or animation or both be used to augment the informational slides? If a presentation will be distributed as a printed handout, will the material include color pages, black and white, or grayscale? How many printed pages can be included in the handout?

Step 3: Outline the Major Points

With a clear definition of a presentation's audience, topic, purpose, location, and delivery medium, a preparer can begin to outline the major points in a presentation. Each major point will probably translate into one or more slides.

Many first-time presenters try to include too much information in their slideshows. Remember that in most presentations, a slideshow is a visual presentation method that should augment and emphasize a presenter's verbal message. Rarely should a slideshow presentation contain all the information the audience members need. Except in stand-alone slideshows designed for presentation at a tradeshow kiosk or online, the presenter is the star of the show. Slides that contain too much text or that make excessive use of format features

(such as color, fonts, animation, and photos) may distract from the presenter and from the central message of the presentation.



Chapter 3 on writing end-user documents contains additional suggestions for developing an outline of a presentation.

Design the Presentation

Step 4: Select a Slide Design

Presentation software packages include a large number of predefined slide themes, sometimes called slide masters or templates, from which a preparer can choose. The purpose of a standard master slide design is to give a slideshow a consistent, professional appearance. Generally, simple master slide designs that do not distract from the information content are more effective than flashy or complex designs (unless the target audience is younger people who may prefer more colorful, creative designs). Many of the format features on a master slide can be modified to create a custom appearance that can be part of a presenter's unique signature.

Other slide design elements are optional, and are probably best omitted, unless specific reasons require their inclusion. Footers fall into this category—they should not be included in a slide master design just because the feature to create them is available in the presentation software. A slide number in the footer may be a useful tool to keep the presenter on track, and a copyright notice should be included when the presentation material is proprietary. Other footer features should be used judiciously.

Step 5: Select a Slide Background and Color Scheme

The background and color scheme, font selection, and other aspects of a slide's appearance can either contribute to or detract from the effectiveness of a presentation. Avoid using a photo or a pattern as a slide background because they tend to overshadow the information content on a slide. Plain backgrounds or ones with simple logos or designs are preferable. Muted colors are often more effective than bright hues that seem to jump off the screen at the viewer. Simple fonts (ones that avoid handwriting, scripts, and stylized fonts) keep the focus on the content.



The general design principle here is that anything that draws the attention of audience members away from the central message on a slide should be avoided. As a presenter, do you want the audience to remember how unusual or fancy or entertaining your slides were, or remember the message you want to communicate?

The selection of design and format elements is an important decision. When in doubt, get a second opinion. Show some design options to a few colleagues you trust and get their feedback.

Create the Presentation Slides

Step 6: Choose a Slide Layout

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Slide layouts give a presenter control over the arrangement of information on each slide. A slide layout is a combination of one or more of (1) a title, (2) contents, (3) objects, and (4) optional footer. Presentation software provides a variety of slide layout options. Each slide layout contains placeholders—a blank space such as a textbox to which a presenter will add content, as shown in Figure C-3. Some placeholders are designed to hold titles for the slideshow; others provide space for text information. Some placeholders are designed to present comparisons between two or more side-by-side content areas. Still other placeholders are arranged to include media objects, such as photos, tables, charts, sound, video clips, diagrams, and maps.

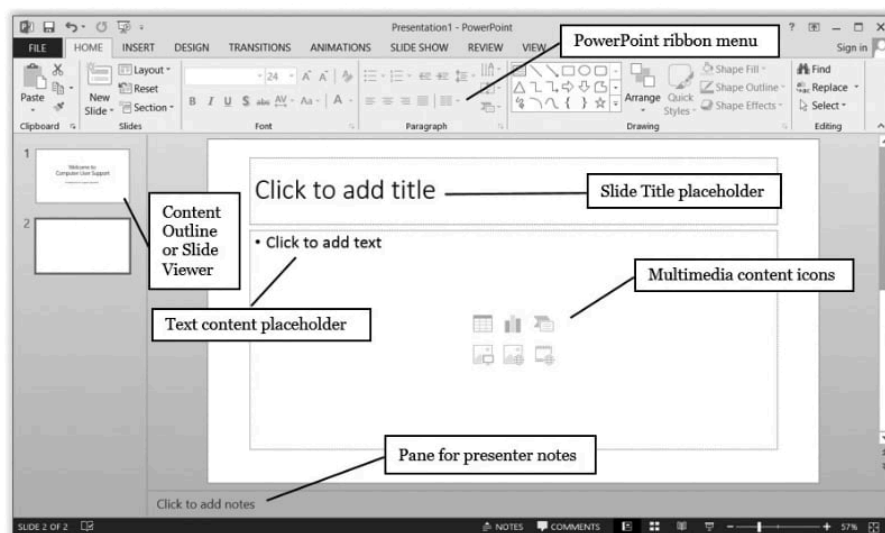


Figure C-3 PowerPoint 2013 slide layout with content placeholders

Source: Microsoft

Slide layouts that use several of these layout elements (or placeholders) should be used with care. When several design elements are included on a single slide, audience members must take time to read a title and text contents, and view other media objects. During the time an audience member is absorbing all of the information content on a slide, they are not focusing their attention on you, the presenter.

Step 7: Prepare the Text for Each Slide

Most slides consist of at least some text information. Here are some guidelines for the preparation of text on a slide:

- Keep text information short; avoid lengthy passages. Information items can be a word or a phrase, rather than a complete sentence. Let white space be the dominant feature of each slide. (A presenter should speak in complete sentences, but the slides don't necessarily have to include full sentences.)



If you find yourself continually reducing the font size on a slide in order to make the information fit, you have probably included too much content. Split a slide when the information becomes too large to fit.

- If a title or phrase extends over more than a single line, help the viewer by using natural breaking points between the lines. Use the title of this appendix as an example and consider various ways to break a title into two or more meaningful lines.
- Keep the number of bullets on a slide to a reasonable number (three to four points is plenty—never more than seven).
- When they view a slide, audience members notice *differences*. Changes in font sizes, different font colors, changes from normal to bold or italic, and differences in alignment or spacing all invite the audience to ask why the differences appear and what the differences mean. Avoid differences for variety's sake, or changes just to make the text fit in the content space.
- To highlight important content on a slide, use a different font size or color, or use the drawing toolbar to add a callout or textbox. But don't overdo the use of these elements to call attention to important content—an audience will tire of looking at information, all of which appears to be of special importance. In other words, use differences in design elements to help your audience figure out what is really important.
- Vary the length of each slide's information content. Avoid creating several slides in a sequence with the same slide layout and with the same number and length of bulleted items.
- Always check the spelling of slideshow content, and if possible, ask a colleague to proofread the content. A proofreader who is not a subject matter expert can often help identify gaps in content as well as mechanical problems.

Step 8: Add Other Objects to Selected Slides, Such as Sound, Photos, Charts, Tables, Movies, Maps, and Diagrams

Multimedia objects can certainly add interest to a slideshow. However, many beginning presenters make the mistake of thinking that each slide must contain something of interest beyond its text content. When used sparingly, multimedia objects embedded in a slideshow presentation can highlight important information or supplement that provided by the presenter. Photos, graphics, sound, color, clip art, maps, and other attention-getting devices are most effective at the beginning of a presentation to grab attention; they may become a distraction if used extensively throughout a presentation.



An exception to this guideline applies to slideshows that are specifically designed to be stand-alone presentations, such as those intended for the web. Stand-alone slideshows can often benefit from more multimedia material because, without a presenter, the slideshow must carry the entire weight of the presentation.

Especially when adding sound, photos, movie clips, and other multimedia materials to a slideshow, a presenter must observe copyright laws and cite the source of materials that are not the presenter's own work.

ON THE WEB

🎥 Guy Kawasaki, a venture capitalist, formulated a 10-20-30 rule for slide design. You can view a short video clip of Guy discussing his rule (www.youtube.com/watch?v=liQLdRkOZiw).

Organize the Slides into a Slideshow

Step 9: Decide on the Sequence of Slides

Presentation software permits a designer to copy, move, and delete slides easily using a slide sorter or other tools. As part of the normal presentation editing process, slides can be moved around, split into more than one slide, or combined with others.

Step 10: Add Transitions or Animation

Use of slide transitions and animation is tricky. Often, nothing is wrong with a transition that simply replaces a slide with the next one in sequence with little or no transition between them. This guideline follows the principle that the mechanical features of a slideshow should not detract from the information content. However, some presenters use simple transitions, such as a rapid fade, to add interest to the presentation. If so, keep the transitions simple, smooth, and consistent throughout the slideshow—in a word: unobtrusive. If audience members are wondering from which direction the next slide will fly in, or whether the presenter has an even trickier dissolve planned for a future slide, they are likely not focusing on the message.



Presenters should avoid transitions between bulleted items on a slide, where the presenter must click to reveal each new bulleted item. Let audience members view a slide's entire contents, and avoid the distraction of transitions between bullets.

Generate Handout Materials

Step 11: Create Presenter Notes

Most presentation packages include a feature to add presenter notes to a slide. See the bottom of Figure C-3 as an example. These notes do not appear on the screen during a presentation or in handout materials, but are reminders to the presenter to discuss additional information or check in with the audience to see if they are following along with the presentation.

Step 12: Create Handouts

Because training sessions, project team reports, and other presentations are usually one-time events, many presenters choose to prepare and distribute handouts of a slideshow to participants. Handouts can consist of a reduced-size version of each slide and, optionally, space for audience members to take notes next to each slide.

Deliver the Presentation

Presenters may want to review the suggestions for trainers in Chapter 11, especially the 10 guidelines listed in Figure 11-6 and described on the pages that follow the figure. These suggestions apply equally to any presentation in which a slideshow is featured. If you have followed the discussion in this appendix, you know that effective presenters design slideshow materials that are simple, rather than elaborate; that are short, rather than lengthy; and that supplement the presenter, rather than steal the show. Figure C-4 contains some additional tips on slideshow presentations.

